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Changes in Nubian wedding ceremonials

Author(S): Al-Katsha, Samiha

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FIRST STAGE: PRE-WEDDING PREPARATIONS • *Firrgar* (betrothal).

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Firrgar (betrothal).

In old Diwan the betrothal was an important part of the process of marriage, and there were several forms of it. When a girl reached puberty it was the duty of her parents or guardian to find her a suitable mate from among her nearest male relatives. Betrothal negotiations were generally started by the boy's family as soon as his parents thought it the proper time for their son to get married. The proper time depended to a great extent on the maturity and the economic standing of the boy (i.e., whether or not he had a job or was working in the fields).

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It was very important to have negotiated an agreement before the official betrothal between the families of the prospective bride and groom; the *firrgar*, or official day of betrothal, followed shortly. This occasion involved primarily the male members of the groom's immediate family and his friends. The latter assembled in the groom's house, from where they all, with the exception of the groom, proceeded in a group to the bride's house.

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The formal procedures then started with the father or male guardian of the groom approaching the guardian of the bride: "We come to ask for a favor. We come to ask for the hand of your daughter for our son." The guardian replied: "The honor is ours. The girl is your daughter and the boy is our son." Since

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755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511

Issues and Bugs: hraf-support@yale.edu

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